

“A REVOLUTION IS NOT A BED OF ROSES.”

Fidel Castro, prime minister of Cuba from 1959–76

THE RACE BETWEEN THE US AND USSR TO SEND A MAN INTO SPACE

accelerated in 1959. On January 2, the Soviets launched the first spacecraft to escape Earth's orbit and reach the Moon, **Luna 1**. The US also had its first successful mission this year, when the **Juno 2** rocket sent the **Pioneer 4** probe toward the Moon. **Luna 2** was launched on September 12, and on October 7, pictures taken by **Luna 3** gave mankind its first look at the **far side of the Moon**.

Cuba had been ruled by a **series of dictators**, culminating in the corrupt regime of **Fulgencio Batista** (r. 1940–44 and 1952–59). A group of revolutionaries led by law student **Fidel Castro** took up arms and set up a base in the Sierra Maestra mountains, provoking Batista to indiscriminate repression. Batista's regime collapsed, and **Castro took over**—he was sworn in as prime minister on February 16. A “honeymoon” period with the US soon ended as Cuba became a **totally socialist state**.

In **Vietnam**, northern guerrillas under **Ho Chi Minh** (1890–1969) attacked the southern army in March. Ho Chi Minh aimed to unite



FIDEL CASTRO (1926–)

Fidel Castro was jailed for his revolutionary activities in Cuba in 1953. After his release he went into exile, but returned in 1956. He was Cuban prime minister from 1959–76 and the first communist head of state in the Americas. His relations with the US were originally good, but speedily deteriorated. Although still a prominent figure, he retired as president in 2006.

Vietnam under communist rule. The US, seeking to stop the spread of communism, trained the **Army of the Republic of Vietnam** (ARVN) and provided advisors to South Vietnam. On July 8, two Americans were killed by Viet Minh troops. These were the first American deaths in the **Vietnam War**.

The **Dalai Lama**, the spiritual leader of Tibet, fled his country on March 31 and **escaped to India** with his ministers. This came after widespread **open rebellion against Chinese rule** within Tibet, which had culminated in a full uprising. Thousands

were reported killed as **China suppressed the revolt**. Over the next few months, an estimated 80,000 Tibetans fled to India.

Antiapartheid riots continued in South Africa. Those in the township of **Sharpeville** resulted in the deaths of 70 demonstrators, and the **African National Congress** (ANC, see 1994) was banned. These events prompted **worldwide condemnation** of South Africa's apartheid policies. When the British prime minister **Harold Macmillan** visited the South African parliament in February 1960, he made a speech highlighting the “**wind of change**” which he believed would bring independence for black Africans.



VW Beetle

Produced by the German company Volkswagen, the Beetle survived the war and decorated Beetles became a symbol of peace around the world.



John F. Kennedy and his wife, Jacqueline, smile from the back of an open-top car during Kennedy's inauguration celebrations.

THE STRAIN ON DIPLOMATIC TIES BETWEEN CHINA AND THE USSR

became public in June, at the congress of the Romanian Communist Party, when **Nikita Khrushchev** and China's **Peng Zhen** clashed openly. The Soviets were alarmed with China's “**Great Leap Forward**” (see 1958), while the Soviets reneged on their earlier commitment to help China develop nuclear weapons, and were seen as too conciliatory to the West. At a meeting in November, the Chinese delegation clashed with the Soviets again, but eventually a compromise was reached, preventing a formal split.

The **Belgian Congo** became independent on June 30, ushering in a period of turmoil. It was renamed the **Federal Republic of Congo**, with Joseph Kasavubu as president, and Patrice Lumumba—a socialist—as prime minister. In July, the province of Katanga declared independence and asked for Belgian help—Belgium sent an invasion force in response, causing Kasavubu to **appeal to the UN**. In September, Kasavubu dismissed Lumumba as prime minister, and in December he was arrested. **Lumumba was murdered** the following year.

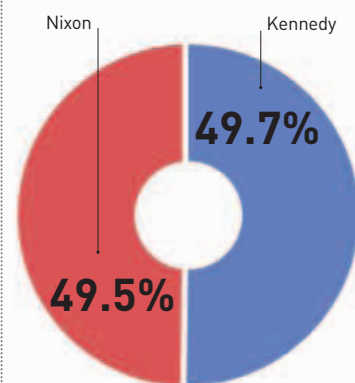
In September, the major oil-exporting countries outside the communist bloc set up the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (**OPEC**). They combined to fix oil prices by controlling supply (see 1973).

The **laser** was first operated on May 16. A device that emits an intense beam of light, it was

invented by the US physicist **Theodore Maiman** (1927–2007). It drew the attention of scientists around the world and led to **advances** in engineering, medicine, and technology.

The influential civil rights activist **Martin Luther King** (1929–1968) rose to international prominence in the early 1960s. King was arrested in Atlanta, Georgia, during a “sit-in” on October 19. He was sentenced to a four-month term in prison. Presidential candidate **John F. Kennedy** (1917–1963) intervened to secure King's release after eight days in jail.

John Fitzgerald Kennedy was elected as 35th President of the US in November. He narrowly defeated the Republican candidate Richard Nixon after some fiercely contested television debates.



Race for the White House

The presidential race between Nixon and Kennedy was incredibly tight. Kennedy beat Nixon by less than 1 percent—just 118,574 votes.

